

road to take stock, to make sure we're on the right path. The question is how far to look. Lining things up for "the rest of our lives" or "forever" seems a little much. I never know what to say, for example, when people ask if I'm going to live in Argentina "forever," or if I'm going to stay retired "for the rest of my life." How in the hell should I know? That's like asking a 5-year-old where she wants to go to college.

But most of us can stretch our imagination two years out. That's long enough to get a sense of direction in our lives. If we don't like what we see, with two years ahead of us we have time to change it.

Take the two-year test every six months or so. Consider your leisure, your family, your hobbies, and your job two years out. Will you still look forward to going to work in the morning? (Or at least most mornings.) Will your work life continue to be rewarding? Will you still be able to grow?

If you answer yes to those questions you're on a roll. You're living through one of life's best phases. You're no more ready to retire than is a 27-year-old graduate from Yale Law School. Enjoy the good times while they last.

If you take the two-year test and decide you're uneasy with your job, you may need a job change. Talk about your options with a headhunter or someone else you can trust. If you can't find a new job that appeals, consider going for a second career. You can go back to law school, open a hardware store, or buy a car dealership. Most of us go through life with a job change or two. Some of us make a career change or two.

But one day, and you may be 35 or 65, you'll look out two years and get bored with the whole idea of work. You'll feel burned out on the job—any job. You'll want to shake free from the whole concept of work and get on with the rest of your life.

When does burnout hit? For me it came when I was in my mid-30s. Some men—Sam Walton may be an example—seem